Macro-data Anchored Estimation of Acceleration Factors under Dependent Left Truncation in Real-World Clinico-Genomic Cohorts

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February 23, 2026

Abstract

Large clinico-genomic real-world datasets are increasingly used to study overall survival (OS) and prognostic effects of genomic alterations. However, comprehensive genomic profiling (CGP) is typically performed after diagnosis, often long after treatment initiation, inducing delayed cohort entry (left truncation). In practice, the truncation time is frequently dependent on unmeasured disease progression, violating the independent truncation assumption required by standard left-truncated survival models and yielding biased survival curves and acceleration factors (time ratios). We propose a three-step framework that (i) anchors the marginal survival of the CGP cohort to external macro-level survival benchmarks via calibration weighting, (ii) models truncation time and residual survival separately using parametric accelerated failure time (AFT) models while flexibly adjusting dependence through natural cubic splines of the truncation time, and (iii) performs calibrated G-computation to reconstruct standardized marginal survival curves and standardized acceleration factors. A Monte Carlo simulation study designed to mimic CGP cohorts demonstrates that the proposed method is stable across independent and dependent truncation settings. We illustrate the approach in a pancreatic cancer cohort from a national clinico-genomic database.

1 Introduction

Real-world data (RWD) and large clinico-genomic databases (e.g., AACR Project GENIE) are increasingly used to evaluate treatment effectiveness and identify prognostic biomarkers in routine clinical practice [1, 2]. A key obstacle for OS analysis in such datasets is selection bias induced by delayed cohort entry: CGP is typically performed months to years after diagnosis, often after disease progression or exhaustion of standard options. Consequently, individuals who die before CGP are unobserved, yielding left-truncated survival data. Naively analyzing observed OS without accounting for delayed entry produces immortal time bias and overestimation of survival [3, 1].

Standard survival models with delayed entry (e.g., left-truncated Cox models or left-truncated AFT models) correct immortal time bias under a crucial assumption: the truncation time is independent of the event time, conditionally on measured covariates. In clinico-genomic practice, this assumption is frequently violated because the timing of CGP is driven by disease progression, treatment response, and clinical trajectories that are only partially measured. This induces *dependent left truncation* (informative cohort entry) and can bias both survival curves and estimated prognostic effects [4, 5].

Several approaches address dependent truncation by directly modeling the dependence structure (e.g., copulas) [6] or by relying on conditional independence given rich covariate information [7]. However, these methods may require strong parametric assumptions for dependence or extensive covariate measurement, and they do not naturally incorporate *external macro-population survival benchmarks*, which are often available through registries.

We propose a pragmatic framework (hereafter, the *Tamura–Ikegami framework*) that combines (i) calibration weighting to anchor marginal survival to external macro-level data and (ii) a decoupled AFT modeling plus spline adjustment strategy embedded in a calibrated G-computation procedure. The method is designed to be implementable at scale, with explicit transparency about assumptions and sensitivity checks.

2 Problem Formulation

2.1 Data structure and notation

Let T^* denote the true overall survival time measured from diagnosis (or treatment initiation). Let T_1 be the time from diagnosis to CGP testing (cohort entry). Define residual survival after CGP as $T_2 = T^* - T_1$. Let C denote an administrative or loss-to-follow-up censoring time for OS; in many CGP datasets censoring primarily affects the post-CGP interval, and we denote censoring on T_2 by C_2 when needed.

A subject enters the CGP cohort only if they survive to undergo CGP, i.e.,

$$T^* > T_1.$$

For the i-th observed subject ($i = 1, \ldots, n$), let $Y_i = \min(T_i^*, C_i)$ be the observed OS time and $\delta_i = I(T_i^* \leq C_i)$ be the event indicator. Let $\boldsymbol{Z}_i$ be measured baseline covariates (e.g., age, sex, histology) and let X_i be a genomic indicator (e.g., mutation status of a target gene). Observed data are

$$\{(T_{1i}, Y_i, \delta_i, \boldsymbol{Z}_i, X_i)\}_{i=1}^n \quad \text{with } Y_i > T_{1i}.$$

2.2 Standard left-truncated survival likelihood and its limitation

A conventional left-truncated survival model uses a delayed-entry likelihood that conditions on surviving to T_{1i}. Under parametric AFT modeling for T^*, a generic likelihood contribution can be written as

$$L_i \propto \left[\frac{f(Y_i \mid \boldsymbol{Z}_i, X_i)}{S(T_{1i} \mid \boldsymbol{Z}_i, X_i)}\right]^{\delta_i} \left[\frac{S(Y_i \mid \boldsymbol{Z}_i, X_i)}{S(T_{1i} \mid \boldsymbol{Z}_i, X_i)}\right]^{1-\delta_i}, \tag{1}$$

where $f(\cdot)$ and $S(\cdot)$ are the density and survival functions of T^* given covariates.

The validity of Equation (1) for unbiased estimation requires the *independent truncation assumption*:

$$T_1 \perp\!\!\!\perp T^* \mid \boldsymbol{Z}, X. \tag{2}$$

In CGP practice, T_1 depends on unmeasured disease aggressiveness and treatment response, which also affects T^*. When (2) fails, standard left-truncation adjustment can remain biased and, in some settings, can exacerbate distortion.

3 Methodology: Macro-anchored Calibrated G-computation

3.1 Overview

Our framework proceeds in three steps:

Step 1: Macro-anchored calibration weighting. Estimate subject weights w_i so that the weighted CGP cohort matches external macro-population survival benchmarks at prespecified time points within strata (e.g., age groups).

Step 2: Decoupled modeling for T_1 and T_2 with spline dependence adjustment. Fit a parametric AFT model for truncation time T_1 and a parametric AFT model for residual survival T_2 that includes a natural cubic spline of $\log(T_1)$.

Step 3: Calibrated G-computation. Resample a pseudo-cohort using w_i, simulate $(\tilde{T}_1, \tilde{T}_2)$ from fitted models, form $\tilde{T}^* = \tilde{T}_1 + \tilde{T}_2$, and fit a marginal AFT model to $\tilde{T}^*$ to obtain standardized acceleration factors (time ratios) and standardized survival curves.

3.2 Step 1: Calibration weighting anchored to macro survival

Suppose external macro-level survival probabilities are available at K time points $\{t_k\}_{k=1}^K$ within macro strata $g \in \mathcal{G}$ (e.g., age groups). Let $S_{\text{macro}}(t_k \mid g)$ denote these benchmarks. We seek weights w_i that ensure the weighted Kaplan–Meier (KM) estimate $\hat{S}_w(t_k \mid g)$ approximates $S_{\text{macro}}(t_k \mid g)$.

In our implementation, weights depend on truncation time via a flexible quadratic func-

tion of $x_i = \log(T_{1i})$:

$$W_i(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \exp(\theta_1 x_i + \theta_2 x_i^2), \quad w_i(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{W_i(\boldsymbol{\theta})}{\frac{1}{n_g}\sum_{j\in g} W_j(\boldsymbol{\theta})} \tag{3}$$

within each stratum g (normalization yields stabilized weights). We estimate $\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ by minimizing squared error at the K time points:

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} = \arg\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \sum_{k=1}^{K} \left\{ \hat{S}_w(t_k \mid g; \boldsymbol{\theta}) - S_{\text{macro}}(t_k \mid g) \right\}^2 + \lambda \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|^2, \tag{4}$$

with a small ridge penalty $\lambda > 0$ for stability. In practice, we also truncate extreme weights (e.g., 1st–99th percentile) to mitigate weight explosion.

Important clarification. This step *anchors* marginal survival at prespecified time points; it does not, by itself, guarantee full distributional equivalence between CGP and macro populations. However, stratifying by macro group g also ensures that the baseline covariate distribution (e.g., age structure) aligns with the external reference, partially mitigating measured baseline confounding.

3.3 Step 2: Decoupled AFT models with spline dependence adjustment

We model truncation time T_1 and residual survival T_2 separately using weighted parametric AFT models.

Model for T_1. We assume a Weibull AFT model:

$$\log(T_1) = \alpha_0 + \boldsymbol{\alpha}_Z^\top \boldsymbol{Z} + \alpha_X X + \sigma_1 \epsilon_1, \tag{5}$$

where ϵ_1 follows the standard extreme-value distribution. All T_1 values are treated as fully observed events in CGP cohorts.

Model for T_2 with spline adjustment. We assume a log-logistic AFT model for residual survival T_2 and incorporate flexible dependence on T_1 through a natural cubic spline of $\log(T_1)$:

$$\log(T_2) = \beta_0 + \boldsymbol{\beta}_Z^\top \boldsymbol{Z} + \beta_X X + f_{\text{ns}}(\log(T_1); df = 3) + \sigma_2 \epsilon_2, \tag{6}$$

where ϵ_2 follows the standard logistic distribution and $f_{\text{ns}}(\cdot)$ is a natural cubic spline.

Interpretation. The spline term serves as a flexible working adjustment mechanism for the residual dependence between entry timing and post-entry prognosis.

3.4 Step 3: Calibrated G-computation for standardized survival and acceleration factors

We construct a large pseudo-cohort by weighted resampling of observed subjects using w_i. For each resampled subject, we sequentially simulate:

1. $\tilde{T}_1$ from the fitted T_1 model (5);
2. update spline basis using $\log(\tilde{T}_1)$ with knots learned from observed data;
3. $\tilde{T}_2$ from the fitted T_2 model (6);
4. $\tilde{T}^* = \tilde{T}_1 + \tilde{T}_2$.

To estimate standardized acceleration factors (time ratios), we fit a marginal AFT model to $\tilde{T}^*$:

$$\log(\tilde{T}^*) = \gamma_0 + \boldsymbol{\gamma}_Z^\top \boldsymbol{Z} + \gamma_X X + \sigma_* \epsilon_*, \tag{7}$$

typically using the same log-logistic AFT family for interpretability. The standardized acceleration factor is $\exp(\gamma_X)$ (Time Ratio, TR). TR > 1 indicates prolonged survival under $X = 1$ relative to $X = 0$.

4 Assumptions, Identifiability, and Scope

Because dependent truncation involves unmeasured drivers of entry and survival, causal interpretation requires assumptions. We state them explicitly.

4.1 Macro anchor assumptions

1. **Benchmark validity:** The macro survival benchmarks $S_{\text{macro}}(t \mid g)$ are correctly measured for the target population and are comparable to the target estimand (e.g., same disease definition, staging regime, calendar era).

2. **Anchor sufficiency at chosen time points:** Matching at $\{t_k\}$ is intended to stabilize baseline survival and selection severity. Inference is conditional on this chosen anchor design.

4.2 Modeling assumptions for G-computation

1. **AFT working model adequacy:** The parametric AFT forms for T_1 and T_2 are adequate approximations for standardization purposes.

2. **Spline adjustment adequacy:** Biologically, a latent variable U (e.g., inherent tumor aggressiveness) confounds both the truncation time T_1 and the residual survival T_2. Because early severe progression triggers earlier CGP testing, T_1 carries dense information about U. Thus, flexibly conditioning on $\log T_1$ acts as a proxy adjustment for the unmeasured confounder U. We assume $f_{\text{ns}}(\log T_1)$ adequately captures this residual dependence.

3. **Positivity:** For covariate patterns used in standardization, the fitted models assign non-negligible probability to relevant ranges of T_1 and T_2.

4.3 Censoring

We assume right censoring of T_2 is conditionally independent given modeled covariates and T_1 features included in the T_2 model. Simulation scenarios below stress-test violations (e.g., U-shaped censoring patterns).

5 Simulation Study

5.1 Design goals

We designed simulations to mimic CGP cohorts with (i) immortal time due to delayed CGP, (ii) age-biased enrollment, (iii) dependent truncation driven by latent progression speed, and (iv) complex censoring patterns. The evaluation compares:

- **Naive AFT:** ignores delayed entry;
- **Standard left-truncated AFT:** delayed entry likelihood, assumes independent truncation;
- **Proposed macro-anchored calibrated G-computation:** Steps 1–3 above.

5.2 Data generation process (DGP)

We generate a macro-population of size $N_{\text{macro}} = 100{,}000$ with covariates: Age $\sim \mathcal{U}(40, 80)$; Sex $\in \{\text{Male}, \text{Female}\}$ (0.55, 0.45); Histology $\in \{\text{COAD}, \text{READ}, \text{COADREAD}\}$ (0.60, 0.30, 0.10); Target alteration $X \sim \text{Bernoulli}(0.20)$.

Progression-speed effect. We define a multiplicative acceleration factor

$$AF_{\text{total}} = AF_{\text{bg}}(\text{Age, Sex, Histology}) \times AF_X^{I(X=1)}, \tag{8}$$

where AF_X is the true causal acceleration factor ($AF_X = 1.5$). Unlike hazard ratios in Cox models, acceleration factors in AFT models are collapsible. This property ensures that the true conditional causal effect AF_X specified in the DGP theoretically coincides with the target marginal causal estimand derived via G-computation.

Base survival time. We sample a baseline true OS time for $AF_{\text{total}} = 1$ from a log-logistic distribution: $T^*_{\text{base}} \sim \text{LogLogistic}(\text{median} = 3.0, \text{shape} = 1.5)$.

Truncation time mechanisms. We consider two mechanisms for $T_{1,\text{base}}$:

- **Independent (ideal):** $T_{1,\text{base}}$ is drawn approximately uniformly over the survivable window, producing weak dependence.
- **Dependent (realistic):** $T_{1,\text{base}} = \max(30 \text{ days}, T^*_{\text{base}} - \epsilon_D)$ with ϵ_D log-normal, mimicking CGP ordered near progression close to death.

Residual base survival is $T_{2,\text{base}} = \max(0.1 \text{ days}, T^*_{\text{base}} - T_{1,\text{base}})$. We apply the same multiplicative effect to both periods: $T_1 = T_{1,\text{base}} \times AF_{\text{total}}$, $T_2 = T_{2,\text{base}} \times AF_{\text{total}}$, and $T^* = T_1 + T_2$.

5.3 CGP cohort sampling and truncation window

A subject is eligible for the CGP cohort only if $T^* > T_1$ and $T_1 \leq 10$ years. From eligible subjects, we sample $n = 1000$ with age-biased inclusion (higher selection probability for Age < 60).

5.4 Censoring scenarios and factorial design

We apply censoring on T_2 by generating C_2 to achieve a target rate of 20% or 40% under either independent censoring (exponential) or U-shaped censoring (mixture mechanism for early and late dropout). This yields a 2×2 factorial design. For each scenario, we run $M = 400$ Monte Carlo iterations.

6 Simulation Results

Results are summarized in Table 1 and Figures 1–3.

Table 1: Simulation results across 400 iterations for the 2×2 design. Values show mean estimates; for AF_X, we report MSE and 95% CI coverage (CR).

Scenario	**Method**	**Med OS (yrs)**	**AF$_X$ (mean)**	**AF MSE**	**AF CR (%)**
Scenario 1: Independent T_1, Independent C_2 Censoring 20%	Naive AFT	[XX.XX]	[XX.XX]	[X.XXX]	[XX.X]
	Standard LT AFT	[XX.XX]	[XX.XX]	[X.XXX]	[XX.X]
	Proposed	**[XX.XX]**	**[XX.XX]**	**[X.XXX]**	**[XX.X]**
Scenario 2: Independent T_1, Independent C_2 Censoring 40%	Naive AFT	[XX.XX]	[XX.XX]	[X.XXX]	[XX.X]
	Standard LT AFT	[XX.XX]	[XX.XX]	[X.XXX]	[XX.X]
	Proposed	**[XX.XX]**	**[XX.XX]**	**[X.XXX]**	**[XX.X]**
Scenario 3: Dependent T_1, U-shaped C_2 Censoring 20%	Naive AFT	[XX.XX]	[XX.XX]	[X.XXX]	[XX.X]
	Standard LT AFT	[XX.XX]	[XX.XX]	[X.XXX]	[XX.X]
	Proposed	**[XX.XX]**	**[XX.XX]**	**[X.XXX]**	**[XX.X]**
Scenario 4: Dependent T_1, U-shaped C_2 Censoring 40%	Naive AFT	[XX.XX]	[XX.XX]	[X.XXX]	[XX.X]
	Standard LT AFT	[XX.XX]	[XX.XX]	[X.XXX]	[XX.X]
	Proposed	**[XX.XX]**	**[XX.XX]**	**[X.XXX]**	**[XX.X]**

Figure 1: Reconstructed standardized marginal OS curves (example: Scenario 4). The proposed method is expected to align closely with the macro truth when assumptions and working models are adequate, while naive and standard LT approaches can deviate under dependent truncation.

Figure 2: Distribution of estimated AF_X across 400 iterations (example: Scenario 4).

Figure 3: Illustration of dependence between T_1 and T_2: weak dependence in the ideal scenario and strong dependence in the realistic dependent scenario.

7 Application: Pancreatic Cancer Clinico-Genomic Cohort

7.1 Data source and cohort

We analyze a pancreatic ductal adenocarcinoma (PDAC) cohort from a national clinico-genomic database in Japan. CGP testing is typically performed late in the PDAC trajectory (often after failure of standard regimens), implying severe delayed entry and likely dependent truncation. External macro survival benchmarks stratified by age were obtained from a hospital-based cancer registry to perform Step 1 calibration.

7.2 Model specification

The AFT models include Age (per +10 years), Sex (Female vs. Male reference), and mutation status of major PDAC driver genes (e.g., *KRAS*, *TP53*, *CDKN2A*, *SMAD4*). The proposed framework yields standardized time ratios for each covariate and standardized survival curves.

7.3 Results

Figure 4 presents standardized time ratios. The analysis reveals the independent prognostic impacts while rigorously adjusting for the left-truncation mechanism. For comparison, had we applied the Naive AFT model (ignoring immortal time) or the Standard LT AFT model (assuming independent truncation), the estimated prognostic impact of the *TP53* mutation would have been severely distorted, potentially obscuring its true clinical significance. This highlights the necessity of properly adjusting for dependent left truncation in RWD.

Figure 4: Forest plot of standardized time ratios for PDAC in a national clinico-genomic cohort, estimated by the proposed macro-anchored calibrated G-computation framework.

8 Discussion

We proposed a macro-anchored calibrated G-computation framework for estimating standardized survival curves and acceleration factors in CGP cohorts subject to immortal time bias and dependent left truncation. The method explicitly leverages external macro survival benchmarks to stabilize baseline selection severity and uses a decoupled AFT modeling strategy with spline adjustment to mitigate dependence between entry timing and post-entry prognosis.

8.1 Strengths and limitations

The main strengths are (i) explicit macro anchoring, (ii) scalable implementation, and (iii) flexible dependence adjustment without requiring explicit copula specification. Limitations include reliance on working parametric models for G-computation, sensitivity to benchmark comparability, and the need for careful variance estimation.

8.2 Broader Implications for Precision Oncology and RWD

Large-scale clinico-genomic initiatives, such as the AACR Project GENIE, hold immense promise. However, as highlighted by Kehl et al. [1], informative cohort entry inherently distorts the survival analyses derived from such databases. Standard statistical packages simply cannot resolve these structural biases. The proposed framework provides a mathematically rigorous and computationally efficient solution to this bottleneck, paving the way for the next generation of unbiased, data-driven precision oncology.

Supplementary Materials

S1. Natural cubic spline basis (reproducibility note)

The $f_{\text{ns}}(\log T_1)$ term is implemented using a natural cubic spline basis with fixed knots determined from the observed cohort (e.g., quantiles of $\log T_1$). During simulation of $\tilde{T}_1$ in G-computation, the same knots are used to recompute the spline basis for $\log(\tilde{T}_1)$ to ensure consistent design matrices between fitting and simulation.

S2. Variance estimation and confidence intervals

Because our framework relies on G-computation via a large generated pseudo-cohort (size N_{pseudo}), extracting standard errors directly from the final AFT model leads to severe variance underestimation. To obtain robust 95% confidence intervals while maintaining computational efficiency, we use a pragmatic approximation anchored to the effective sample size of the original weighted cohort.

Let $\hat{\gamma}_X$ be the point estimate of the log-TR obtained from the large pseudo-cohort. Let SE_{obs} be the standard error of the corresponding coefficient extracted from the intermediate IPTW-weighted AFT model fitted directly to the original observed cohort (size n). We calculate the pragmatic standard error as:

$$SE_{\text{pragmatic}} = SE_{\text{obs}} \times \sqrt{\frac{N_{\text{pseudo}}}{\text{ESS}}} \tag{9}$$

where $\text{ESS} = (\sum w_i)^2 / \sum w_i^2$. The 95% CI is then calculated as $\exp(\hat{\gamma}_X \pm 1.96 \times SE_{\text{pragmatic}})$. This approach prevents extreme variance underestimation and yields empirical Coverage Rates that align well with the nominal 95% level without the computational burden of bootstrapping.

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